



metro PLUS

THE HINDU



Strap in as a 113-year-old choir from Chennai performs Henry Purcell’s baroque orchestra P2

SARDAR 2: THE SPY WHO WEARS A LUNGI P4

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“**H**ey karuppan vaaraandaa,” signals the entrance of actor Suriya in the climax of *Karuppu*, where, in a near-unrecognisable transformation, he appears as lord Karuppasamy. When the RJ Balaji-directorial released in theatres in May, Tamil cinema embraced a long-lost identity – the devotional film, known in the industry as the *saami padam*.

Karuppu could be the first sign of a larger revival. *Seyon*, starring Sivakarthiskeyan; *Mookuthi Amman 2*, starring Nayanthara; *Thamizh Murugan*, starring Dhanush; *Vettaisaamy*, starring Arulnithi; and *Jiiva*’s untitled project on lord Murugan are some of the devotional films in development. Sources say several such projects will be announced in the upcoming months.

Many recent Tamil films now also feature dialogues of a religious nature or elements; for example, the scene featuring Karthi wielding the Vel in *Sardar 2*. Lord Murugan also seems to be gaining popularity in the non-film music circuit: take Sivakarthiskeyan’s song ‘Velum Mayilum,’ Vaaheesan’s hit indie ‘Kaakum Vadivel,’ and the indie song ‘Vetrivel’ from Kelitheer, ofRO and Santhosh Narayanan.

What triggered this trend? Arulnithi says he didn’t get the memo. “I don’t know. We started *Vettaisaamy* one and a half years ago, and when I listened to the narration, there was no such trend.”

This is not an unfamiliar concept for Tamil cinema; devotional themes dominated much of the cinema that came out in the 1950s and 1960s. Even until the 1990s and early 2000s, a slew of Tamil films on deities like Amman, Iyappan, and Mother Mary were made

“Directors like AP Nagarajan made many devotional films that showed deities in the Ravi Varma style; because nobody has seen God, they had to rely on his paintings for the imagery. That’s how we got many quintessential ‘saami padam,’ starring stalwarts like NT Rama Rao, Shivaji Ganesan and Gemini Ganesan,” says actor and film historian Mohan Raman.

However, that trend fizzled out by the mid-2000s. “You had to shoot those films on set, but erecting sets and designing costumes and jewellery is expensive. Moreover, old-school visual



As a slew of devotional films are set to return to theatres across India, we look into the factors that lead to the revival of the ‘saami padam’ in Tamil cinema

Divine intervention

effects started to seem too tacky. And computer graphics hadn’t grown to that extent in India at that time,” reasons Mohan.

Then, in 2020 we saw a revival of the Amman sub-genre in Tamil, with Balaji’s *Mookuthi Amman*.

Gods over super heroes
The most obvious reason is in Mohan’s statement on what led to the decline of the ‘saami padam’ in the 2000s. “Over the last five or seven years, the cost of special effects has dropped dramatically. CGI is no longer something only a Rajinikanth picture can afford,” says Mohan.

Ideally, a decline in production and special effects costs should have led to riskier attempts, or perhaps a slew of superhero and horror films. So why go devotional? Mohan says traditional film producers believe “that because it’s a film on a deity, the divine will protect them from losses.” Experienced producer PL

Thenappan, known for backing films like *Kaathala Kaathala* and *Panchathantiram*, counters that cinema offers no guarantees. “If we had that guarantee, everyone would even sell their house and make one such film. If your effort is honest, even a small film like *Tourist Family* can hit the jackpot,” says the producer.

So, perhaps the answer to what’s driving this trend lies outside the borders of Tamil Nadu.

Nationally, there has been a resurgence of devotional themes. The

Kannada hit *Kantara* proved that rooted stories on regional deities can win big. Meanwhile, many mega-budget films on religion and mythology – like *Brahmastra*, *Hanu-Man*, *Kalki 2898 AD*, *Mahavatar*

Narasimha, and *Kannappa* – have drawn huge audiences. Currently, *Ramayana*, *Varanasi*, and Jr NTR’s film on Murugan are in production.

Director H Vinoth, whose film *Jana Nayagan* was released recently, too, believes this could reflect India today. “I look at it as a result of a change in the political scenario of the country. It doesn’t matter whether these films are necessary; this trend was inevitable. This is just the beginning, and I believe it will only get more intense as everyone jumps in to cash in.”

Mohan, who is set to feature in a supporting role in Rishab Shetty’s *Jai Hanuman*, asks us to look at how potent the idea of God as a protagonist is. “It lends a lot of grandeur, which is now essential for a big-screen film to be differentiated from streaming content. You need that sense of ‘wow’, and that comes easily when you are dealing with a God. If you say Karuppasamy flies, they will believe you. If you say Superman is flying, you need to justify it, especially to non-multiplex audiences or rural audiences.”

All those factors combined make films on gods a good bet for a producer, and the film industry has a habit of following the money. Whenever a film achieves significant success, more films replicating that formula follow, says Mohan. “Many biopics

tasted success, which is why many biopics are being made now. This is like a cycle; there will come a saturation point, and once again, audiences will seek thrills in murder mysteries or cop stories, and after that trend dies down, romance stories will be the trend, and so on.”

Why stars are playing gods
Interestingly, this new phenomenon is altogether different from the films we saw before 2010.

Firstly, modern filmmakers tend to humanise the divine, like in the case of *Karuppu* or *Kantara*. As Mohan concurs, “they show the divine in the form of an ordinary citizen – maybe he is possessed by the deity, or maybe the deity has taken birth in an ordinary family, and so on. They bring god down to earth and make them more reachable.”

Secondly, big Tamil stars like Suriya and Dhanush are enthusiastic about playing



Having a God as a protagonist lends a lot of grandeur, which is now essential for a big-screen film to be differentiated from streaming content

MOHAN RAMAN
Actor and film historian



about these gods should not end up propagating hatred. “This trend will cause conflict over historical memory. Learning one’s history is important. But if it ends up instilling hate in you, that hatred will destroy you. Watch these religious or historical films, see where you lost in the past, and try to better yourself,” he advises.

A year ago, even an infrequent cinema-goer might have expected Tamil cinema to remain in familiar territory: violence, drug smuggling, revenge and socio-politics. Now, a slew of devotional films is promising to turn theatres into prayer rooms. Tamil cinema’s original heroes are reclaiming their throne.

BRIEFLY



Toy Tonics takes Chennai

Get ready for a feel-good night of dancefloor energy. Canvas brings Toy Tonics to Chennai with the Berlin-born label’s spirit to the city. Expect a mix of house, disco, funk, soul, and jazz, with Gee Lane, Arpy Brown and friends. Whether you are there to dance, explore new sounds, or simply soak up the atmosphere, this is a night designed to keep the groove going. @Canvas by Sketch, Alwarpet. On September 12, 7 pm. Entry strictly for ages 25 and above, with a valid government-issued ID required. Tickets at kynhood.com



Alternate reality

An underground film festival in Chennai? Sign us up. At Nizhalgal Film Festival 2026, find independent cinema by established and emerging filmmakers bringing us wildly interesting stories with panel discussions in Tamil and English. Organised by the Art is War Collective and Ing Art House, the festival presents 30 independent works spanning 16 shorts, eight short documentaries and six features, curated by filmmaker and critic Arjun K. @Flyerz Studio, Kottivakkam. September 12 and 13, starting 9.15am. Tickets are priced between ₹150 and ₹450 on kynhood.com



A journey through song

The Silken Braid is a musical journey through modern India, bringing together stories and original songs gathered along the travels of musician Arjun Chandran. Reflecting the traditions and influences of the places encountered, the performance is presented entirely on a 12-string resonator guitar. This is the inaugural edition of Mother Tongue Music’s Live Sessions, a monthly series exploring alternative live performance. @Vinyl and Brew, Alwarpet on September 12, 6pm onwards. For ticketscall: 9176984695



Four bands. One night.

Brutal Carnage XVII returns with four bands together for the 17th edition of Chennai’s underground metal series. Progressive metal outfit Trojan Horse makes its return after more than a decade, alongside Bengaluru’s XrepeatX making its Chennai debut, Wacken Metal Battle India 2022 winners Moral Putrefaction, and thrash-death metal outfit Severed Extremities. Expect and an uncompromising night of underground metal. @Palomar by Crossway, Akkaraai on September 12, 6pm onwards. Tickets on outworld.fanpit.live

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Henry Purcell is a celebrated English composer of the baroque era, a man who lived and died in the shadow of Westminster Abbey. The great strains of music that spilt over from the abbey's organ influenced his score, and when he died in 1695, he was buried adjacent to the organ.

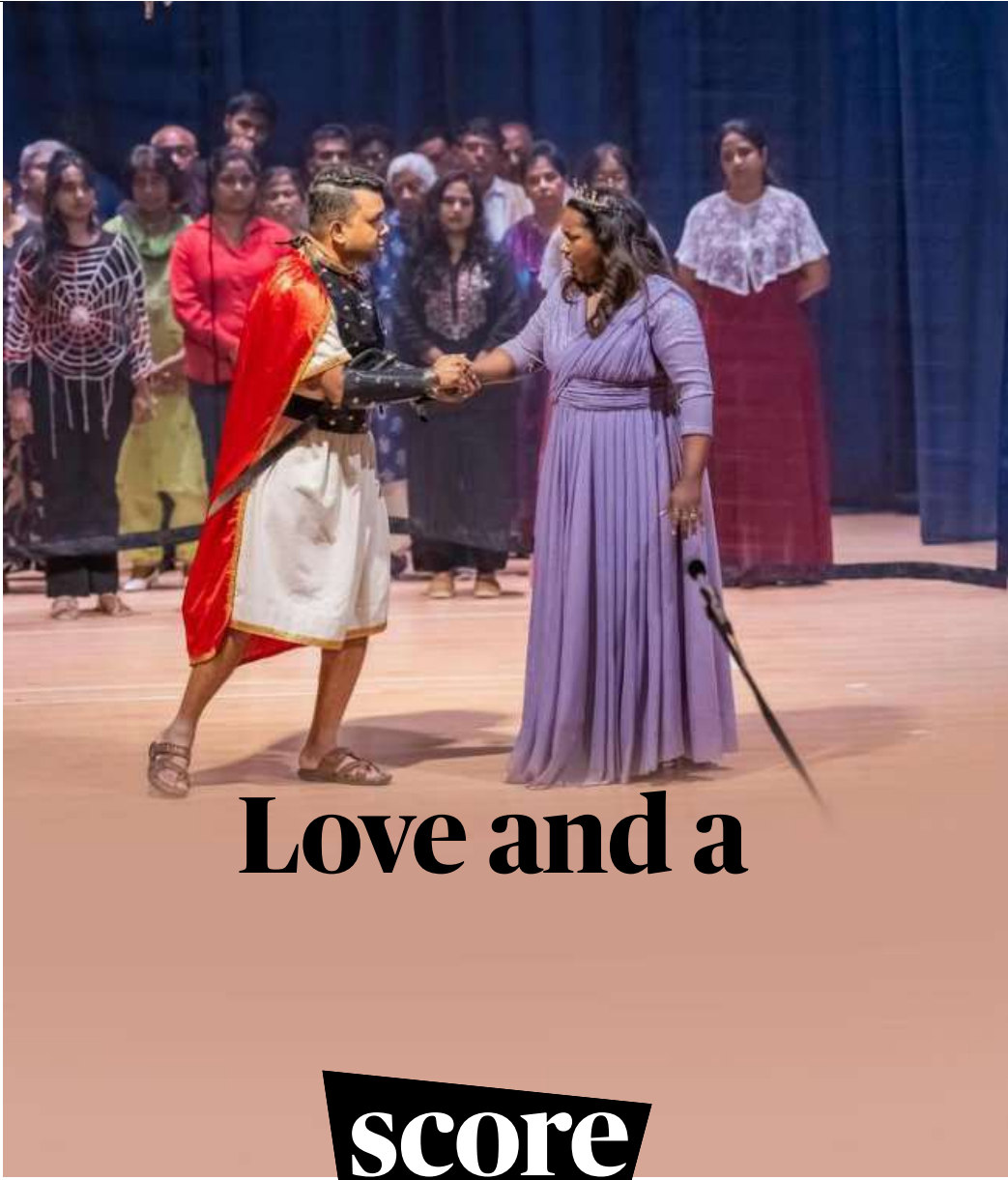
In Purcell's vast repertory, *Dido and Aeneas* stands as bright as a lighthouse, casting its searching light on Dido, the queen of Carthage and her beloved, the Trojan hero Aeneas. A story of love, duty, betrayal and loss, it is an opera that singers often flock to with Dido's 'Lament' a crowning highlight. The opera is drawn from Roman poet Virgil's *Aeneid*. Across the world, the opera has had its seasons in the sun and later languished in obscurity for years.

Now, the 133-year-old Madras Musical Association and its Chamber Orchestra will perform the opera at the exalted stage of the Museum Theatre, Egmore. But why Purcell, I ask MMA conductor Augustine Paul.

"English operas are few. The ones by later composers like Benjamin Britten are complicated. Purcell is the opera star, later followed by Handel. He wrote in English, the latter wrote in Italian. Over the years MMA has performed plenty of songs from the operas of Gilbert and Sullivan and Rodgers and Hammerstein. But we have not performed Purcell," says Augustine.

Dido and Aeneas, an hour-long production, requires spare backdrops but demands emotional heft from its performers. "Another reason why this was chosen is because it is a smaller production, only three acts, in comparison to the ones by composers Wagner or Verdi that run to at least three hours," says Augustine.

Purcell's work also suits a smaller cast and a chamber orchestra. The MMA's live chamber orchestra will



Love and a score

The 133-year-old Madras Musical Association will stage Henry Purcell's celebrated baroque opera at the Museum Theatre with a chamber orchestra and an all-MMA cast

perform from the pit of the Museum Theatre – its acoustics require fewer mikes. "The Museum Theatre does not have a large pit so we have to really scramble if we choose a bigger production. For Purcell, we have exactly the right number of instruments needed. The audience can see both the production onstage and the musicians. Opera is the ultimate test for an artiste to express oneself as a singer and emote at the same time as an actor. It requires mastery of both.

The production is entirely sung," adds Augustine. This immersive experience of soaring music, dramatic storytelling and theatrical spectacle is choreographed and directed by Deepa Nambiar, who has worked in theatre for 22 years and directed five productions so far, including last year's MMA production *Cinderella*. "This is my first experience in direction and choreography for an opera," says Deepa. "What is common to



The stage is set Scenes from a rehearsal of *Dido and Aeneas*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

all productions is the ability to bring a narrative alive. The difference in opera is how we do it. It has a quiet intensity that it brings to the audience and the actors/musicians have to keep alive that inner fire of paradoxes to live the character authentically. When I heard the music, the only visuals that danced before me were that of the period in which this music was created."

The MMA's live chamber orchestra will perform from the pit of the Museum Theatre — its acoustics require fewer mikes

The entire cast and crew is drawn from the MMA, whose members also handle costume design and music. "The orchestra, though small, comprises young musicians, mostly college students and professionals," says Augustine. Principal soloists will include Roshni Sharon, Prashanth Gasper, Cathlin Esther and Ebenezer Arunkumar.

Dido and Aeneas will be staged at Museum Theatre, Egmore on September 10 and 11 at 7pm. Tickets priced at ₹500, ₹1,000 and ₹2,000 are available at BookMyShow, MMA Choristers, Aspire Music Conservatory, Etude School of Music and Musee Musicals. For details, call 9840485558.

Get groovy

Squirrels in the Attic is set to bring British Invasion music along with stories and trivia at Bay 146



Finish the lyrics Sindhuja Sankaran and Saira Jacob, lead vocalists of the band Squirrels in the Attic. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Did you know that Eric Clapton's 'Layla' was born out of his unrequited love for Pattie Boyd, the wife of his close friend and Beatles legend George Harrison? Or that Phil Collins' 'Another Day in Paradise' is about a privileged passer-by who sees suffering but chooses to walk on?

Sindhuja Sankaran, lead vocalist of Squirrels in the Attic and a psychologist, will be speaking about the stories, inspiration and little-known trivia behind some of the biggest names in Western music at Bay 146 Resto Lounge on September 11, when the cover band performs a British Invasion tribute show.

The British Invasion is a 1960s musical movement that saw the pop and rock acts from the UK gain massive popularity across the world. "The Beatles' arrival in New York City marked the beginning of the movement. We will also be symbolically

starting this show with a Beatles song," says Sindhuja. She adds, "We are very genre-fluid. We have done classic rock, 80s rock, retro, alternative Indie, pop rock. For our coming show, we want to explore music across the years and look at how British music and British artists evolved," she says.

The band's setlist will feature around 25 artists, which includes songs such as Queen's 'Don't Stop Me Now', Deep Purple's 'Burn', Eric Clapton's 'Layla' and Coldplay's 'Viva La Vida', spanning different eras and sounds.

Sindhuja also shares that her band reinvents and experiments with songs that they are performing. "As musicians, what is the point if we're just going to do a carbon copy of the original? We don't want to do that. At one gig, we took ABBA's 'Mamma Mia' and made it slow, with just piano, bass and vocals."

The show is on September 11 at Bay 146. Tickets are priced at ₹250 on district.in



Shop local, thrift better
KURA is a curated thrift pop-up bringing together thrifted fashion, local brands, handmade creations and hidden finds under one roof. The Chennai-based pop-up is designed to spotlight sustainable fashion and local creators, offering visitors a chance to discover unique pieces, and support small businesses.
@Backyard, Adyar on September 12, 4pm to 8 pm. Entry is ₹100. To register and for details, call: 9677148864.



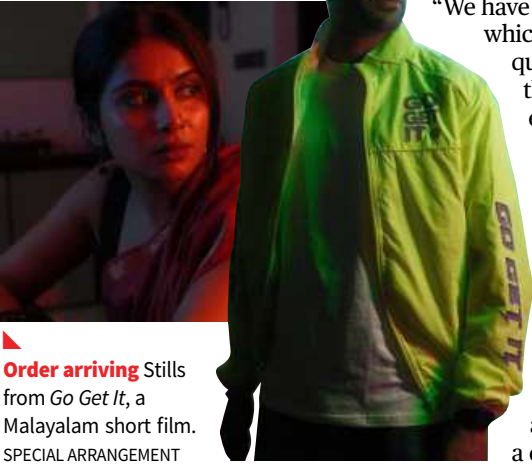
What happens when a five-minute delivery app glitches and sends everything to the wrong doorstep? Avaan Ajit Menon's darkly comic short film turns quick commerce into a chaotic, dystopian playground

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In the age of e-commerce, it is not unthinkable to believe that there can be an app from which anything can be purchased. It is, to an extent, a reality. Everything from cooked meals, and electronics, to a suitcase and even a treadmill can be purchased and delivered to your doorstep. What happens if we take that reality a step further?

Set in an alternate universe Kochi, exists the app Go Get It, and contrary to the name, you do not have to go anywhere to get anything. Everything can be delivered to your doorstep. Drugs, weapons, food, harmful medicines, toys, everything you desire is now just five minutes away. There is no concept of legal or illegal in this universe.

Go Get It, a short film directed by Avaan Ajit Menon, takes this exaggerated premise and turns it into a dark comedy about a world that has become entirely dependent on convenience. "I usually make films in the thriller genre. In fact, I thought of this as a thriller where



Order arriving Stills from *Go Get It*, a Malayalam short film. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the delivery boy gets involved in the lives of different characters. Then I thought, okay, what if it's a comedy? And then I had this idea about an app that gives you everything. Everything, literally everything!" says Avaan.

Toxic dispatch
For producer Tuhin Menon, it was the world that immediately made the idea compelling – particularly its potential to satirise quick-commerce culture that has become woven into everyday life. "We have not seen something which is a sharp satire on the quick commerce culture that we live in, and how everyone's reliant on these platforms. The core idea was what happens if something you're so reliant on, glitches. It's a dystopia, which is why we've called it a parallel world," he says. The glitch at the heart of *Go Get It*, which sends one customer's delivery to another's location, sets off a chain of increasingly

dangerous mix-ups, with a delivery rider Parcel Panicker (George Kora) at the centre of the chaos.

As he moves through this strange version of Kochi, the film brings him into contact with a collection of eccentric characters. What begins as a seemingly routine delivery, quickly pulls the rider into the lives and peculiarities of the people at the other end of the app.

In one amusing sequence, mafia don Amal (Tuhin Menon), places an order for a weapon to kill his next target, only to receive a box of poisoned chocolates ordered by another customer who is depressed at the news of his favourite Malayalam star Mohanlal retiring. Amal and his henchmen eat the chocolates, while the intended target, tied to a chair and awaiting his fate, is spared and gets a good laugh at their expense.

Adding to the film's playful unpredictability are appearances by Malayalam stars Arjun Ashokan and Mamta Mohandas, who play themselves. They are seen shooting for an advertisement for the app!

At another tangent, Parcel's partner Shruthi (a stunning Gayathri Satish) just wants to go out with her friends, but he is having none of it. He is a star delivery boy by night and a controlling partner by day. On an already chaotic day, she gets a parcel she did not even order and that might just be her way out of this toxic relationship. It is through these seemingly random encounters that *Go Get It* builds its peculiar, irreverent world, where a technological glitch can upend lives in ways no algorithm could predict.

Beneath the absurdity is a pointed look at how deeply convenience has seeped into everyday life, and what happens when a system designed to make everything effortless suddenly stops working as it should. For the cast and crew, however, this is only the beginning. They have built a world that they believe could extend well beyond the short film, and are now waiting to see where audiences take it.

Go Get It is currently streaming on the Asiaville Malayalam YouTube channel.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #70
(Set by Doppelganger)

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Across

1 Academic gown (4)
3 Woodworking tool (5,3)
9 Fat (7)
10 Dodge (5)
11 Found at children's park (5)
12 Avaricious (6)
14 Sailor (6)
16 Take on loan (6)
19 Be frugal (6)
21 Trident (5)
24 Excuse (5)
25 Old wind instrument (7)
26 Rebel (8)
27 Money charged for professional services (4)

Down

1 Evaluate again (8)
2 Light pancake (5)
4 Come into view (6)
5 Corpulent (5)
6 Tremble with fear (7)
7 Cry (4)
8 Open balcony (6)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 70

S	E	E	J	E	O	V	D	E	N	E	N	
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O	N	I	R	V	O	I	B	I	L	I		
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The parai throbs with life when struck with a wooden *kuchi* (stick). What if it can make heads turn even without its resonant beats? For the past three years, a team of five scientists at the Chennai-based CSIR-Central Leather Research Institute have been trying to colour on the pale brown surface of the percussion instrument, made of dried buffalo hide stretched over a circular wooden frame.

They have finally succeeded – the result is a technique that can render the parai colourful, even producing tie and dye patterns on its surface. M Sathish, Senior Scientist, led the team whose research at the institute under the Ministry of Science and Technology, Government of India’s CSIR, was headed by Chief Scientist B Madhan and guided by P Thanikaivelan, Director, CSIR-CLRI. The new technology has the potential to change the way parai is seen. “People look at the instrument with a certain disdain,” says Sathish, who works between Chennai and Kolkata. Traditionally associated with funerals, parai and the artisans who play it, many of whom are from oppressed communities, are treated below par to other classical instrumentalists and musicians. “The sole purpose of our research is to change this,” he adds. Parai has been seeing a

Colour my parai blue

A team at CSIR-Central Leather Research Institute has developed a technique to colour the percussion instrument

new wave in the recent past with young men and women, and even children across Tamil Nadu embracing it. Sathish worked closely with parai artisan M Gurunathan, who also handcrafts the instrument. “He provided us grassroots-level information from artisans across the State, which was crucial for our research,” says Sathish. Their project, funded by the Council of Scientific & Industrial Research’s Fast Track Translation Research Project, didn’t just come up with a technology to make the instrument colourful. “We were also able to render the hide more resonant and sturdy so that artisans don’t have to keep replacing it after every four or five events like they usually do,” he adds. “The hide tends to develop fungus if exposed to moisture and the surface can sometimes have prickly hairs, making it

particularly difficult to be carried abroad. We were able to resolve both these issues.” Gurunathan, who was a bridge between the scientists and artisans, was part of the first team of eight that signed an MoU with the Institute for knowledge transfer at the Rise startup conclave earlier this year in Chennai. “Most of the artisans from the team were from Dindigul, and there was also a chendamalam artisan from Kerala,” says Gurunathan. Once they grasped the nuances from the scientists, they started making colourful parai themselves.



To buy miniatures and coloured parai, call 9884842227.

A new wave At a demonstration in which Gurunathan (left) and artisans from across Tamil Nadu participated; a miniature parai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Gurunathan, who has been making and playing parai for 24 years now, is experimenting with tiger skin print. “I’m also trying out Warli art, block printing, and am open to customising based on the musician’s requirements,” he adds. Sathish says that colourful parai can also make for a collector’s item. “They can be displayed at home on the wall. Artisans are also making miniatures that can be gifted,” he says. “This will add value to the instrument, taking it to more people.” From painting faces on the instrument to getting shapes stencilled on it, options are now aplenty and Sathish says that more research is underway. Gurunathan’s team took a set of coloured parai to be played at an event by Anandha Traditional Arts & Music in Singapore in August this year. “Several musicians from countries such as Malaysia and China were curious about it,” he says, adding that they left behind a few to be displayed at an upcoming museum in Singapore. From an instrument that people were hesitant to touch to becoming a collector’s item, parai is on its biggest journey yet.

Let's get saucy

No face, no name, just bold flavours. Here is what goes on at Pulip Party on September 12



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Did you know that an anonymous hot sauce-maker has been part of the Chennai food scene since the start of the pandemic? Five years ago, Amy (this is the most he'll reveal about himself), a black mask-clad entrepreneur running an Instagram page, reviewing food spots in Chennai decided to take a leap of faith and launch his own brand: Maadi Mart. His experimentation and experiences from his travels to locations like Serbia and Georgia, had him selling flavoured ghee, chilli crisps, curry leaf zaatar cured egg yolk chips, and a range of hot sauces, at pop-ups and exhibits across the city. He also held Maadi parties two years ago, cooking feasts from different parts of the world including Japan, Peru, and Cambodia, once every two weeks for friends and enemies, as part of a pop-up on his terrace. “Ever since I was young, I



Break a leg Pulip party’s team makes jerk chicken. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

was obsessed with food. It’s probably because my mother was an excellent cook. When I was in school, I’d have the coolest lunches. She would make me pizza and Subway burger buns from scratch. I entered the world of IT because I needed to make money but my heart was always in the culinary space. Over the years, I have travelled to 23 countries, trying to familiarise myself with cuisines from many different places. Corona Cookery, my page, started as a result of that,” he says. Amy experimented extensively with his content and his pop-ups, serving up pieces of mortadella and other dishes every fortnight. He made a

series on food from Iran when the war between the country and Israel was underway, and a set of videos from the North East of India, eating everything from bugs to drinking local liquor. When he came back, he wanted people around him to try food from these locations. Pulip Party, a second attempt at a terrace pop-up with his friend and content creator Praveen Duraivelu, set to take place on September 12 at the founder’s terrace in Ramapuram. It is deliberately small in scale and has only a limited number of seats available for booking via Instagram. The first edition of the event draws on Jamaican staples like oxtails (a coco bread and oxtail curry), an ice cream, chicken patties, jerk chicken, and dried fish, all reimagined with local ingredients. Amy feels like the typical Chennai eater is hesitant to try new cuisine but there is a growing audience that wants to eat unfamiliar food. “I promise inauthentic but great food. I don’t intend to import the most expensive ingredients from the world while we have potential substitutes in Chennai. Why use a Scotch bonnet pepper when there’s a bhoot jolokia. My aim is to be unapologetic with cooking. I will not be diluting dishes to suit local preferences. If a recipe calls for beef tongue, I will use it. Food in Chennai need not just be briyani, parotta or pizza,” he says. Expect to receive goodies including a T-shirt, he adds. More events are soon expected to take place in restaurants across the city with the next planned for Atlas House. It’s time to get saucy.

Pulip Party will be at Michael Garden, Ramapuram on September 12. The meal will be priced at ₹1,499. Follow Amy on @pulipparty on Instagram for details.



Bagging rights

The Postbox opens their first experience store in the city, for customers to engage closely with the bags they want

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A 40-year-old independent house tucked away in a quiet lane in T Nagar is The Postbox’s new home. The accessories brand, which specialises in bags, wallets, and other carrying goods, made Chennai its base nearly a decade ago, and for CEO and creative director Nikhil Joseph, this first experience store has been a long time in the making. It, after all, finally marks the brand’s move from a digital-only presence to a physical space. “Over the years, we have had customers from Bengaluru, Mumbai, and even Dubai stop at our warehouse and pick up bags. We realised that our target

group, customers between the ages of 27 to 45 years, are self-aware. They are particular about the material of their bags and wallets. An experience store hence felt essential and timely,” Nikhil explains. The brand now stocks a range of bags in different styles: crossbody, duffels, backpacks, messengers and more, all crafted in leather or a special nylon canvas sourced from Germany. All of this is thoughtfully on display at the new space, which Nikhil worked on with his wife, Vaishali Srinivasan, founder, 85:15. If one corner is dedicated to travel, another has their range of leather goods. Apart from the space being an extension of his aesthetic, Nikhil also says he envisions a third space here, which can host



workshops, interesting pop-ups, and more community-focussed gatherings. “I have only ever seen all my products on a catalogue on the website all these years, so it feels great to actually see it all under one roof,” he laughs. Alongside this are samples of their nylon canvas with ink droppers and water, where customers can check to see its water resistance. This is for people to slow down and touch the fabric of a brand they associate only with leather. While they do have leather products like their pebbled napa leather line, a majority of their bags are a mix of

Keep me posted (Clockwise from right) At the experience store; and products by The Postbox. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



materials and some, entirely made of this canvas. **Design evolution** “There are many, who are as obsessed as I am, about the very granular details that go into a bag. Did you know there are active forums online, especially on reddit, focussed on carrying goods,” he asks. The cobra locks on their backpacks, detachable straps on laptop bags, dedicated slots for everything from cables to lipsticks, and even a special air tag sleeve are all very conscious human-centric and functional design choices that Nikhil says many geek out over. As the brand continues to grow, Nikhil emphasises on not wanting to be known as a ‘friendly, neighbourhood leather goods store’. “Our presence might have been small, but we have been steadily scaling up. This experience store as well, we hope, will be a trial of sorts, for a larger-format space in the future,” he adds. The Postbox is at 2/20, Singaram St, T. Nagar. Priced from ₹1,599 onwards.



Quick, caffeinate Mango matcha and Spanish latte SANGITA RAJAN

The hidden brew

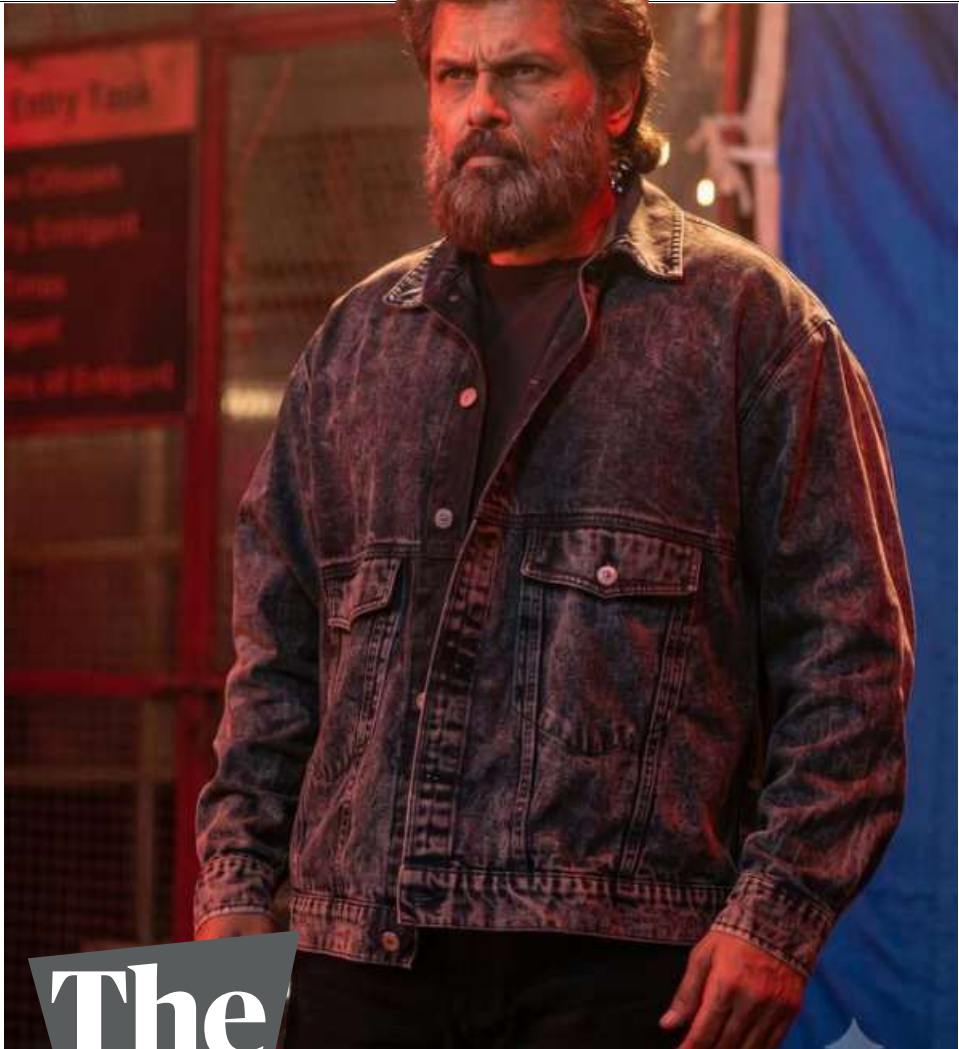
Rhythm Coffee in Alwarpet serves Vaanam, Solai, Kairee and Maalai, four speciality roasts from Tamil Nadu and Karnataka

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If you, like me, have a permanent residence on one particular social media app and live in Chennai, you must be subjected to the endless tirade of videos calling everything from Erode Amman Mess to a local thrift store a ‘hidden gem’. Naturally, it did not take long for the internet to present the same title to the newly opened Rhythm Coffee in Alwarpet. This Harry Potter’s cupboard-under-the-stairs-esque coffee bar with minimal seating and a well-tested menu, is the new feather added to Chennai’s coffee cap. “I was a South Indian filter coffee drinker initially. Then I ventured into black coffee with Americano when I had to stay up late for work. Home brewing began eventually, and it kept going from there,” says Roshan A S, the owner of Rhythm, a cafe in Alwarpet, serving four speciality roasts for the pour-overs. “Each bean we have comes from a different estate. Currently, two are from Tamil Nadu and two from Karnataka, and each has been processed differently and gives different results. We want to keep these beans rotating every year with the harvest season,” he says. The beans available currently are – Vaanam from Valparai, which has floral and citron notes; Solai from Kodaikanal, a rare Yellow Bourbon Arabica with notes of allspice and citrus; Kairee from Chikmagalur, a raw mango fermented bean; and Maalai from Chikmagalur, dried with rose petals with notes of rose and lychee. Apart from speciality pour-overs, Rhythm serves a range of coffees, matchas, and non-caffeinated beverages. The orange pound cake latte is scented with orange peel and olive oil and has a rich finish that would have been more enjoyable if served hot instead of lukewarm. Rhythm also does an Indian take on the Mont Blanc called the Blanc. It is a

cold brew layered with sweet lime juice instead of orange and topped with a cold foam and zest – a refreshing twist that works well unexpectedly. The Spanish latte is the perfect drink for those who prefer a sweet milky coffee. Both the vanilla cloud and the mango matcha were done well. The coffee bar is not the place to hang out for longer than 10 minutes. It can comfortably seat six people or four with their laptops, so takeaways are recommended. They also serve some cakes and pastries, alongside a couple of savoury options, and each is paired with a coffee. Roshan and his baristas are knowledgeable and happy to help even those who are just starting out on their coffee journey and only need a cup to stay awake. For that alone, the place is worth a shot.

Rhythm Coffee is at Alwarpet. A beverage costs approximately ₹350.



The spy returns

Director PS Mithran speaks about taking the spy genre beyond its familiar tropes in Karthi's *Sardar 2*, releasing today

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What makes a good sequel? For filmmaker PS Mithran, it begins with the characters. His favourite sequel, after all, is *Terminator 2*. “In the *Terminator* films, Sarah Connor and John Connor are characters that bring depth to the story. So a great sequel should have good character continuity,” he says. Mithran now hopes that his upcoming film, *Sardar 2*, starring Karthi, will be a good sequel to his 2022 spy thriller. Mithran thought of an idea for a sequel to *Sardar* while shooting a prison sequence in the film. “I realised the titular character had a lot of unexplored potential to tap into.” However, since he had to focus on shooting *Sardar*, he didn't give the sequel idea any further thought. “Then, after the release, when Karthi sir and I were flying back to

Chennai from Hyderabad, we discussed the idea for *Sardar 2*, and I started building that storyline.” Mithran felt exhausted thinking about *Sardar* – remember, this is a character that has been on his mind since before the pandemic. “So I took a break from *Sardar*, and I even did three other scripts.” But everything changed once he cracked SJ Suryah's antagonist character. We have seen Suryah play negative roles recently; however, this is a script tailor-made for him, says Mithran. “He is who he is because of his histrionics. We can't cut that out of him. We can alter the meter of his performance; you will see both a subtle Suryah and a quintessential Suryah in *Sardar 2*.” The trailer for *Sardar 2* promises a high-stakes spy-actioner with grandeur and suspense. Interestingly, however, the three-minute promo is the latest example of a recent trend of long trailers that reveal much of the plot.



“Firstly, in the age of social media, the whole concept of surprise is valid for one show. So what's the point of hiding it all?” wonders Mithran. “At the end of the day, I have written a good story, and I want to sell my film with that story. This is how Hollywood promotes a lot of films – most trailers will give you an idea of the beginning, middle and end.” Speaking of Hollywood, the story of *Sardar* shares quite a few parallels with Christopher Nolan's *The Dark Knight*, a film and a filmmaker Mithran is a huge fan of. Akin to the climax of the 2008 film, *Sardar* ends

The sequel game Karthi on the sets of *Sardar 2*; (below) PS Mithran. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

up taking the blame on himself after the death of a once-good character (Rathore, played by Chunky Panday). So you naturally wonder if *Sardar* is Mithran's second crack at the superhero genre after his Sivakarthikeyan-starrer *Hero*. “Spies are real superheroes in real life. He will be hidden in the crowd as a silent watcher who silently saves people and walks off.” But Mithran says is was not Nolan who inspired him. “I personally would feel that the ending of *Sardar* is very similar to that of *Irumbu Thirai*, and while writing the *Irumbu Thirai* climax, I was inspired by *Mad Max*.” After its release, *Sardar* received mixed reception, and Mithran realised the demography of his audience was wide and dynamic. “If a section of the audience said the second half moved at a brisk pace, another group said they couldn't understand it. So balancing all these expectations was a task in *Sardar 2*.”

The upcoming film will also have genre pleasures, like gadgets, disguises, and coded messages, which appeal to spy-film fans, says Mithran. Writing and shooting some of these ideas – like using a railway station ticket to arrange a meeting in *Sardar* – gives him a high. “When I started approaching *Sardar* as a spy film, I wanted to explore that genre with those things that are visible to our eyes. Usually, if it's a spy film, we would immediately think of some mystical place or a hidden island where the villain is hiding. I wanted to make a spy film without all that.” In *Sardar 2*, Mithran has scaled up and tried some larger-than-life ideas as well. *Sardar* also had a vein of social consciousness – the film spoke of the dangers of using plastic water bottles. Mithran does not want to be tagged as a ‘socially responsible’ filmmaker, but he stresses how spies have historically brought about changes socially and politically. “John Perkins's ‘Confessions of an Economic Hit Man’ is a major inspiration for me; it's a book about how, through building one dam, the CIA was able to take over a whole country.” *Sardar 2*, he adds, also has one such aspect.

Currently, Mithran is in talks with a few producers for his next. He says, “I can't say more, but it definitely won't be another spy thriller.”

Like a beautiful melody

Ahead of *Epic - First Semester*, composer Hesham Abdul Wahab opens up on his choice of projects

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In a warm morning at Ramanaidu Studios, Hyderabad, when composer Hesham Abdul Wahab settles down for this interview, he remarks that he has been at work for 50 hours, taking short breaks of an hour or two to catch up on sleep. He is finalising the background score for director Aditya Haasan's Telugu film *Epic - First Semester*, starring Anand Deverakonda and Vaishnavi Chaitanya, releasing on September 11. In the last four months, he has moved from one finish line to another, composing for the Malayalam film *Madhuvudhu*, Tamil film *Once More*, and after *Epic*, he will finalise the score for his Kannada debut, *Brindavihaari*.

Hesham likens the situation to New Year resolutions. “Just like our fitness and diet regimens go for a toss days after New Year's, each film has a different journey. We just adapt to working under pressure because we love what we do.” At the moment, he is pleased with the reception to *Once More*, which boasts 13 songs, and is confident

that *Epic* will win hearts post-release. Elaborating on *Once More*, Hesham reveals that he and director Vignesh Srikanth were keen to use motifs inspired by the ‘Vaa Kannamma’ song at different points in the film. “Some directors prefer not to use such motifs, while others do. It worked in the case of *Once More*.”

Epic marks his first collaboration with Aditya Haasan. The key characters in the film are an extension of Aditya's debut directorial web series 90's: *A Middle Class Biopic*, which was inspired by his family. Anand plays Aditya, a character inspired by the director's experiences while studying in the UK. “I

have not worked on a film in which some characters are an extension of those from a web series.”

Hesham is glad that he is among the go-to composers for filmmakers who seek melodies. “Our listening history shapes who we are. I grew up listening to composers such as Ilaiyaraaja, AR Rahman, Shankar Ehsaan Loy and Vidyasagar, and I enjoy feel-good music,” says Hesham, whose upcoming projects include a film with Vijay Deverakonda, Sailesh Kolanu's *Emo Emo Idi*, a Malayalam film with Vineeth Srinivasan, and the Tamil film *Superhero*.



A still from *Epic*; (above) Hesham Abdul Wahab.



Mani Ratnam's next titled *Inji Vellam*

Inji Vellam is the title of ace filmmaker Mani Ratnam's much-awaited romance drama starring Vijay Sethupathi and Sai Pallavi. Mani's production banner Madras Talkies announced the news on social media with a motion poster. Details regarding the plot and the rest of the cast are under wraps. According to reports, most of the portions of the film were shot in Kolkata. *Inji Vellam* continues Mani's acclaimed collaboration with composer AR Rahman. The film has cinematography by Avik Mukhopadhyay and editing by Sreekar Prasad. Produced by Subaskaran, Mani and Siva Ananth under their Madras Talkies and Lyca Productions banner, the film is set to release in theatres in January 2027.



Mammooty is Burma Karthikeyan

The makers of *Om - Chapter 1*, Tamil star Dhanush's upcoming film with director Rajkumar Periasamy, have unveiled Malayalam superstar Mammooty's character. The promo shows Mammooty as Burma Karthikeyan, a gangster in an international crime network under investigation by Interpol. We can also see Dhanush's character working under Karthikeyan. *OM - Chapter 1: Udhiram - The Blood Wood* also stars Sai Pallavi and Sreeleela in pivotal roles. With music scored by Sai Abhyankkar, the film has cinematography by Ezhil Arasu K and editing by R Kalaiavanan. Produced by Shraddha Agarwal, Dhanush, and Azmat Jaggam under their Wunderbar Films and RTake Studios banner, the film is set to release in theatres on October 16.

***Dil Chahta Hai* at 25: How Farhan Akhtar's breezy style created a new Bollywood coolth**



Timeless appeal A still from *Dil Chahta Hai*. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

COOL AS WE KNOW IT

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In 2001, three friends forged a fresh on-screen connection. Juggling glittery nightlife, leisurely afternoons, and casually road-tripping to Goa on a whim, Akash, Siddharth, and Sameer liberated Bollywood friendships from the sacrificial, brotherly depictions of the preceding generation, making way for a breezy coolth that splintered harmoniously into its design. The filmmaking relied less on aesthetic excess and more on nurturing likeability by placing the three in mindfully created spaces, in outfits that reflected their inner lives

without making an obvious fashion statement. The effect was disarmingly gleeful. It represented the urban aspirations of being young at the turn of the century by creating a style that was as easygoing as it was vibrant. Part of that youthful appeal came from the instincts of debutant writer-director Farhan Akhtar, who assembled a team of young technicians to realise his refreshing vision of love and friendship. His minimalistic approach was evident in how the characters appeared real, without the cinematic facade

prevalent at the time. The hair styling was done by Avan Contractor, who was working on a movie for the first time. Avan read the script to understand the characters and the world they operate in. Farhan's brief to her was clear. “He wanted the characters to look contemporary, modern, and to give them an urban feel, different from the conventional Hindi film hero. Maybe that's what people found relatable,” Avan says. She points out that the process was similar to the work they did on their clients in the salon. “We would consult the clients, know their likes, dislikes and

preferences, and the possibilities that their hair offered. The same principle was used to work with the actors, to make them look more like their characters.” Perhaps the look that stirred the most conversation was that of Aamir Khan, who played Akash with a playful reckoning, and his earlier sweet-boy on-screen memory of starring in romantic dramas was quickly overshadowed with sharper eyebrows, a longer hairline

extending to the cheeks and a goatee on the chin that sealed the deal with its added quirk. Aamir proposed the idea of a goatee when he came for the haircut, reveals Avan. “He had a beard from his earlier film, and after his haircut, he went to shave the beard and kept coming out to show us different kinds of facial hair. He finally came out with just the goatee, and we felt that it looked super cool.” The same intricate thought prevailed in the production design by Suzanne Caplan Mervanji, who created the indoor spaces related to the characters with an aim to extend their personalities. “I had come to understand that set design is meant to enhance the script and the characters and not distract from them,” Suzanne says. That methodology is seen quite easily in *Dil Chahta Hai* as the rooms of Akash, Siddharth and Sameer hold a distinctive character, placed with minimal objects that make the spaces look more lived-in than overstuffed with ideas. Akash's casual demeanor, transactional outlook, and disbelief in love are reflected in the sleek, mechanical styling of his room. “Being the wealthiest character, he had the most modern, spacious, clean-lined and rather cold set design, to help describe his relationship with his family, friends

and girlfriends,” Suzanne says. The meticulous reasoning behind every visual element helps the film retain its timeless appeal. *Dil Chahta Hai* continues to fascinate film lovers and technicians working in the industry even today. Sabina Halder, the costume designer on *Tu Meri Main Tera Main Tera Tu Meri*, *Call Me Bae*, *Madgaon Express* and *Merry Christmas*, watched the film for the first time as a child and enjoyed it for being a “fun, youth movie”. “I didn't understand the nuances of the film then, but the style of Preity Zinta's clothes was on my wish list,” says Sabina. Now that she works as a costume designer herself, she has revisited the film multiple times to study costume designer Arjun Bhasin's work. “I have observed every small detail in the styling. Every emotion is visually communicated beautifully. It wouldn't be wrong to say that the clothes and styling in the movie keep the happiness quotient high throughout,” she states. Now, over 25 years after its release, Akash, Siddharth and Sameer evoke some warmth that made them stand out then. The songs underline its newness, with the ‘chamkile din’ in the title track creating a charming reverberance. Coming right after the turn of the century, Farhan marked the advent of a new kind of cinematic experience, shifting from soapy drama to a lively coming-of-age rigour. As Javed Akhtar put it in ‘Koi Kahe Kehta Rahe’, *Ham hai naye, andaz kyun ho purana*; clearly, the heart still desires and the style has still not aged.